regard to Berlin." The result of the competition between "two great peoples in Asia" would have a global impact.[10]

In the US, most of the talk about India was now in terms of its potential for achievement. There was high-level discussion on whether the American objective should be "something more ambitious." National Security Adviser Gordon Gray laid out the question, "Was India to serve as a counter-weight to Communist China or was India to be a successful example of an alternative to Communism in Asia?" Eisenhower emphasized that it was not a "black and white" issue. He hoped that some day India would be a "greater counterweight" to China, but the US could not use India as a counterweight since Delhi did not want to play that role. Moreover, in the near term, the US would "bankrupt" itself trying to achieve that goal. Nonetheless, it was "obviously important for the U.S. to help India to prove itself." There was agreement with Under Secretary of State for Economic Affairs C. Douglas Dillon's assertion that it was not enough just to "prevent India from going communist." The US needed to help lay the basis for long-term Indian success. If India thrived, it "might well prove to be a counter-attraction if not a counterweight to Communist China."[11]

India's progress was especially important in the context of increasing Chinese power, which, along with the Soviet economic offensive, was threatening "free world" interests in Asia. Thus it became administration policy to invest in "developing in South Asia, particularly in India, a successful alternative to Communism in an Asian context." After all, "Asia and Africa will be watching and comparing what the Indian and Chinese Communist regimes are achieving for their peoples."[12]

Delhi was making these comparisons with China as well. There was concern that China had indeed taken a great leap forward, and that India was falling behind its neighbor. Foreign Secretary Subimal Dutt wondered, "What lesson is one to draw from the phenomenal progress made by China? There is no easy answer. One might be prepared to sacrifice 'the mechanism of free enterprise' but are we prepared to write an obituary … on political liberties? At the same time, of what good are political liberties if they mean lack of the minimum necessities of life for millions?"[13] But, by summer 1959, while the scale of failure of the Great Leap Forward was not yet apparent, the Indian embassy in China was sending reports of food shortages and other economic difficulties.[14] A few months later, the Indian